

Pocket PC vs Palm OS

For a long time, Microsoft dwelt in the Palm's shadow till they finally got it right with Windows CE v3.0, simply known as the original Pocket PC operating system. Though the Pocket PC is a marvel in itself, there is an alternative out there which offers its own rewards—the Palm OS which was designed with low cost, simplicity and a low footprint in mind. Who can ever forget the wafer-thin Palm V? But in terms of functionality, it is evident that a Palm outfitted handheld looks like a toy that can do small tricks as opposed to Pocket PC's extreme likeness to a desktop computer. Applications that Windows users are accustomed to such as Word, Internet Explorer and Windows Media Player have been ported to lighter and easier-to-use Pocket PC versions. Streaming audio/video, wireless connections (including 802.11b) and its tight integration with its desktop counterparts make transferring more than just address books a reality.

So with all its bonuses, why is the Pocket PC's market share only 25 per cent of that of Palm? Microsoft must pay heed to Palm's massive devel-

oper support and the availability of Palm accessories; finding Palm applications is child's play thanks to the community-centric support that it boasts of. Secondly, the Pocket PC was essentially designed to do more, and as a result, the device costs more. An entry level Pocket PC starts at around Rs 20,000 while a Palm gadget comes at less than half that amount. Although Microsoft is fully aware of these facts, it is pinning its hopes on multimedia and wireless applications to justify the price tag.

Both Palm and Microsoft realise that in order to boost their positions in this phase of handheld growth, corporate acceptance is imperative. With the specialised services of the Palm OS and Pocket PC's exorbitant price tag, currently, both are tailored to suit the needs of businessmen rather than the average consumer. But once the cost dynamics tilt in favour of the Pocket PC, Palm could possibly be on its way to the grave. If Palm even wishes to dream of long-term survival, the company needs to shift its focus away from its software's proprietary nature.

press it. Writing on a small area doesn't help either; the hand is used to resting on a solid platform as opposed to thin air. In time, you will only have to get used to being careful about how you dot your i's and cross your t's. Even then, you will have to deviate from your natural style of writing.

What's in the offing?

One gadget that's left an impression on the minds of a music-hungry generation is the Sony Walkman, a revolutionary product that founded the personal audio industry. Sony's 'ingenious' strategy is actually quite simple: take a typically immobile object, make it slick, and scale it down enough to fit in your pocket. Unfortunately for handheld makers, this approach will only take them so far.

For handhelds to gain wide acceptance, they need to be easier and more efficient to use. Take browsing for example. Can you imagine trying to navigate your way through the Web with just a stylus complimented by poor handwriting recognition? Instead, why not try and capitalise on a handheld's obvious advantages? Their small screens are ideally suited for a greatly simplified interface that lays more stress on tapping rather than glorified attempts at writing gibberish. As of now, handhelds are years away from voice and handwriting recognition. So if there are more refinements to think about, why are OS makers pretending that their products have done it all right away?

There is no doubt that in the next five years, mobile computers such as these will be as easily accessible as the cell phone today. For one, it will cost around the same. Besides, if you take this technology just a few steps further, there is no reason why a digitally smart and savvy generation won't adopt it.

PRASHANT MASRANI

through their services. Pocket PC uses the host's Internet connection to download pages from the Web during the sync process. Once you subscribe to your favourite channels, the sites' latest updates are downloaded to your Pocket PC the next time you decide to update.

Recognise me?

For years, poor voice and text recognition has been the bane of the mobile computing industry. With the Pocket PC, greater emphasis has been placed on character recognition with the stylus as a writing tool. But the muscle power of handhelds today is a far cry from what it needs to be. Pocket PC's text engine includes a learning module which calibrates itself to the user's unique penning characteristics. The feel of a stylus and touchpad is completely different from that of pen and paper and takes some time getting used to. When writing on this device, you feel no resistance and you need to be lenient about how hard you

1/4 page AD